

## Company Context

### Mission

- What is the company's overarching goal or purpose?

IBM's mission is to lead in innovation through technology and consulting — advancing artificial intelligence, cloud computing, cybersecurity, and data solutions while fostering diversity, equity, and inclusion in the tech industry.

### Vision

- What future state is the company working toward?

To create a future where technology empowers everyone, bridging opportunity gaps and enabling diverse talent — particularly Black women in technology and entrepreneurship — to lead innovation globally.

### Strategic Objectives

- What are the top 3–5 company-level priorities this product should align with?

The SheLeads Innovation Hub aligns with IBM's core company priorities:

1. Advance DEI and Representation in STEM and leadership.
2. Leverage AI and Cloud Technology to empower underrepresented innovators.
3. Strengthen Partnerships with HBCUs, startups, and communities.
4. Expand IBM's Social Impact Footprint through inclusion-driven innovation.
5. Build Future Talent Pipelines that enhance IBM's long-term workforce and brand equity.

## Role of Product

- How does this product contribute to the company's success (e.g., growth engine, retention lever, market entry)?

The SheLeads Innovation Hub acts as a growth engine and social impact platform — driving recruitment, brand loyalty, and innovation. It contributes to IBM's success by:

- Cultivating future leaders and entrepreneurs.
- Expanding IBM's reach in diverse markets.
- Strengthening partnerships with universities and minority-led startups.

## Problems & Opportunities

### Core Problems

- List the key user and business problems your product aims to solve.
  - Example: "Content creators struggle to repurpose short-form videos efficiently."
1. Limited access to advanced tech tools and mentorship for Black women in STEM.
  2. Underrepresentation in technical and leadership positions.
  3. Lack of funding and visibility for Black women-owned startups.
  4. Systemic barriers that prevent equitable participation in innovation ecosystems.

## Opportunities

- Identify where there's potential for differentiation, innovation, or market capture.
  - Example: "AI summarization + auto-tagging can 10x creator productivity."
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1. Position IBM as the leader in inclusive innovation.
  2. Leverage existing tech and DEI resources (AI labs, HBCU programs) to create measurable impact.
  3. Partner with HBCUs and Black-owned startups to co-create scalable solutions.
  4. Differentiate IBM through a mission-driven innovation model combining business growth with social advancement.

## Supporting Evidence

- Include user research, data, or market insights that validate the problem and opportunity.
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- Black women are one of the fastest-growing groups of entrepreneurs, yet face systemic barriers to funding and tech access.
  - IBM's global reputation, AI/cloud tools, and HBCU partnerships can be directly leveraged to close these gaps.
  - Without intervention, IBM risks missing the opportunity to lead in shaping an inclusive innovation ecosystem.

# Product Solution

## Vision Statement

One sentence describing the product's long-term impact.

Example: "An AI workspace that turns every video into searchable, shareable insights."

"An inclusive innovation hub where Black women gain access, mentorship, and technology to lead the future of tech."

## Core Value Proposition

- What unique value does this product deliver that alternatives do not?

IBM SheLeads uniquely integrates technology empowerment, mentorship, and innovation resources in one ecosystem, enabling participants to develop, scale, and lead projects using IBM's cutting-edge tools.

## Key Features / Capabilities

- Summarize the main pillars of your product offering (3–5 max).
- Example:
  - AI segment search
  - Personalized short-form feed
  - Cross-platform embedding
- User Journey / Flow Summary:
  - Outline how a target user moves through the experience.

1. AI & Cloud Access – Participants use IBM Watson, Cloud, and design-thinking workshops.

2. Mentorship Circles – Direct guidance from IBM leaders and partner organizations.
3. Startup Launchpad – Support for business creation, funding access, and visibility.
4. Leadership Pathways – Training for professional and executive growth.
5. Community Portal – A digital hub for collaboration between participants, mentors, and partners.

## Personas

Primary Persona

Secondary Persona(s)

JTBDS

Name: Jasmine, 27 — Black woman software engineer or entrepreneur

Goal: Advance her career and launch a tech startup using AI or cloud tools.

Pain Points: Limited mentorship, funding, and advanced tech access.

Motivation: Representation, innovation, and community impact.

### Secondary Personas

- University Students (HBCUs): Seeking pathways to internships and innovation projects.
- Black Women Startup Founders: Need mentorship, networking, and visibility.
- Corporate Allies: Looking to sponsor or partner with IBM DEI initiatives.

JTBD (Jobs to Be Done):

“When developing my career or business, I want access to mentorship, technology, and resources so I can innovate confidently and advance in my field.”

## Market & Competition

### Market Landscape

- Define the category, growth trends, and macro forces shaping it.
  - Example: “AI-driven content tools growing 40% YoY; creator economy expanding globally.”
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- Category: DEI-driven tech education and innovation platforms.
  - Trends: 40% YoY growth in tech accelerators and digital upskilling programs.
  - Forces: Global expansion of the creator and startup economy; push for inclusive innovation and representation.

### Competitive Analysis

- Direct competitors (similar products)
- Indirect competitors (alternative solutions)
- Gaps in current offerings that you address

**Competitor**

**Focus**

**Weakness**

**Opportunity for IBM**

|                                        |                  |                                 |                                           |
|----------------------------------------|------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Google's Black Founders Fund           | Funding          | Lacks mentorship integration    | Combine funding + IBM tech tools          |
| Microsoft LEAP                         | Career entry     | Limited entrepreneurship focus  | Bridge leadership and innovation          |
| Meta Elevate                           | Marketing skills | Lacks AI/Cloud innovation depth | Position IBM as advanced tech empowerment |
| Nonprofit accelerators (BLCK VC, etc.) | Networking       | Small-scale reach               | IBM offers global platform reach          |

## Differentiation Strategy

- What's your unfair advantage? (tech, data, brand, UX, partnerships, etc.)
- Positioning Statement
  - For [target user], [product] is a [category] that [key benefit]. Unlike [competitors], it [differentiator].

- Unfair Advantage: IBM's AI/Cloud infrastructure, HBCU partnerships, and brand credibility.
- Positioning Statement:

"For Black women innovators, IBM SheLeads is an empowerment platform that provides mentorship, advanced technology, and career pathways. Unlike traditional accelerators, it combines IBM's technical expertise with leadership development and community collaboration."

## Success Metrics

### North Star Metric

- Single overarching measure of long-term value creation — the one metric that defines success for your product or organization.

### Signpost

- Leading indicators that tell you whether you're on the right path toward the True North.

### Guardrails

- Ensure progress doesn't come at the cost of user trust, experience, or sustainability.

## North Star Metric

Number of Black women innovators successfully mentored, funded, or employed through the SheLeads program.

## Signpost Metrics (Leading Indicators)

- Program enrollments and cohort completions.
- Number of active mentorship pairings.
- Number of startups or projects launched.
- Engagement rate in the SheLeads community portal.

## Guardrail Metrics

- Participant satisfaction (≥90%).

- Diversity retention rate.
- Ethical and inclusive program representation.
- Avoid tokenization or under-delivery on promises.

Chosen Methodology:

MoSCoW Prioritization Framework

Reason: Helps focus on the most impactful features first while maintaining clarity for future iterations.

Results:

- Must Have – AI & Cloud Access, Mentorship Circles
- Should Have – Community Portal
- Could Have – Leadership Pathways
- Won't Have – Startup Launchpad (for later phase)

This approach ensures the SheLeads Innovation Hub launches with high impact and aligns with IBM's mission of inclusive innovation.